

Philosophy 101 · Short Assignment 1

Written in section

Name: _____ Section / GSI: _____ Date: _____

Four questions, one per page. Spend about eight minutes on each, so roughly 150 to 200 words, but it's totally fine to write more. Write on the lines; if you need more room, ask for more paper. Handwriting, spelling and crossings-out are not marked.

1. Memory

Jo believes that the Battle of Hastings was in 1066. She is right. She has believed it since she was small, and she cannot remember where she learned it or why she first believed it. Give the best reason for saying Jo's belief is justified, and the best reason for saying it is not. Then say which you find more convincing, and why.

2. Testimony

Two people disagree about testimony. One has the view we called reductionism; they say you should believe what a stranger tells you only if you have some positive reason to think they are reliable. The other has the view we called anti-reductionism; they say you should believe them unless you have some positive reason to doubt them. Describe a situation in which these two give different advice. Then explain why the disagreement between them is narrower than it first looks.

3. Anderson

Occasionally, the scientific community as a whole gets things wrong. For instance, for a long time the conventional wisdom was that stomach ulcers were caused by stress and stomach acid; the real reason was bacterial infection. What does Anderson's view recommend that ordinary people believe in these cases? Is this recommendation reasonable?

4. Nguyen

Sam only ever encounters arguments for one side of a political question. He has never met a serious argument for the other side, and it has never occurred to him that there is one. Mia has met the arguments for the other side many times. She was told, long before she met them, that people who make those arguments are paid to make them, and she has found this to be true of several of them.

Someone hands each of them a well-argued piece from the other side. Say what Nguyen would expect to happen in each case, and why the two cases come apart.